Preparing and Presenting a Poster

HSURV 2026

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Agenda

- Goals of a Poster Presentation
- Telling Your Project Story via Formatting
- Poster Elements
- Posters for Research in Progress
- Submitting Your Posters
- Presenting Your Poster
- Day-of-Logistics

Goals of a Poster

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Your poster:

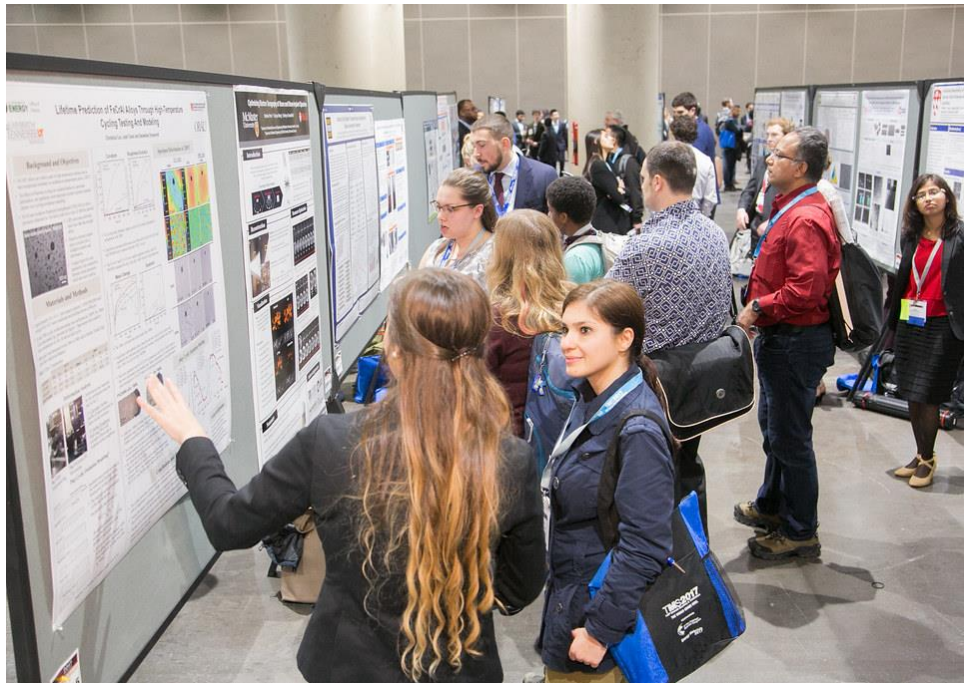
- communicates the most important aspects of your research **at a glance**.
- helps visitors understand the purpose and main findings of your project in just a minute or two.
- invites longer conversation by providing a clear, visual summary of your work.

Five questions your poster should answer

- What problem or question did you investigate?
- How did you approach it?
- What did you discover?
- Why do your findings matter?
- Who supported or contributed to this work?

Engaging an Audience at HSURV

- Assume a sophisticated and educated but general (not domain-specific audience) – and a crowded room!

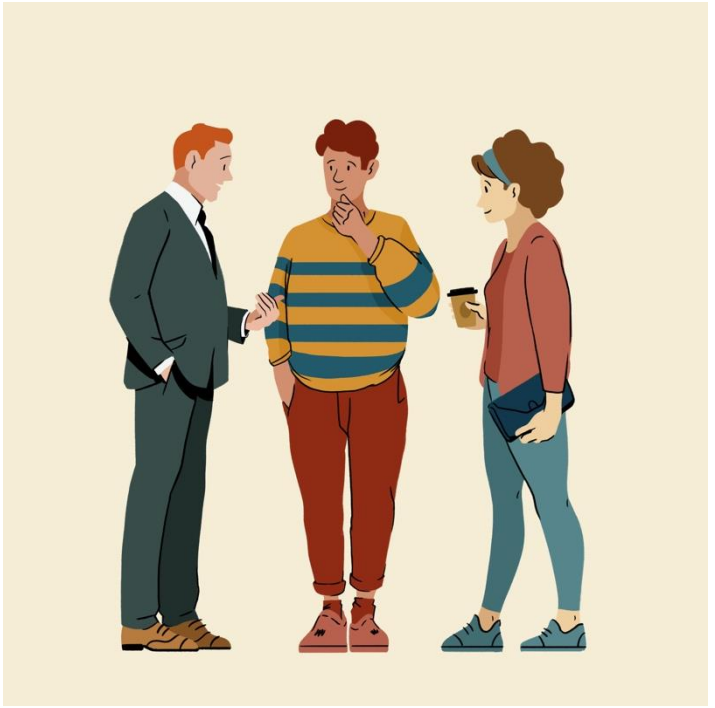


- ✓ **Engage** both with those who know nothing about your topic – and with those who know a lot. Entry points and levels of sophistication.
- ✓ **Communicate** what you are doing and why it matters. Don't jump right into too technical a discussion.
- ✓ **Include** elements that you can point to deepen the conversation with those who may have more background knowledge.

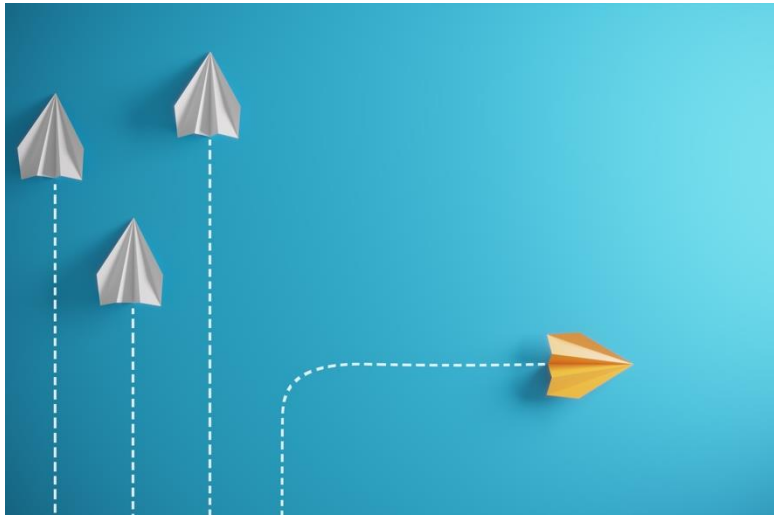
Poster as Provocation for Conversation



A poster is not a paper… don't detail every element!



Use images and figures that will guide you and an audience through your project's story – and open doors to more conversation.



From findings to explanations: **How can *seeing turn into showing and speaking*?** Point the way.

Formatting Your Story

If you do one thing…avoid a wall of text!

In the swirling realm of Chrono-Tapioca, where time is measured in spoonfuls of existential pudding and gravity politely knocks before entering, the League of Sentient Cardboard Conspirators gathered to debate the legality of dream-scented postage stamps. Among them, a philosophical llama named Percival recited Shakespeare backwards while riding a hoverboard made of bureaucratic jellybeans, causing minor temporal hiccups in nearby dimensions ruled entirely by synchronized sneeze etiquette. Over in the capital city of Eclairopolis, the Minister of Umbrellas Who Think Too Much declared all colors illegal except for "mirth," prompting a revolution led by flatulent saxophones and emotionally volatile eggplants that only speak in 18th-century legal jargon.

Meanwhile, floating above the broccoli-based skyline, the Cloud of Mild Regret released inspirational haikus composed by retired calculators, inciting spontaneous jazzercize riots among the population of sock puppets with PhDs in metaphysical nonsense. Beneath the dance floors of Neptune's third moon, where marshmallow tectonics cause periodic outbreaks of involuntary interpretive mime, whispering glowsticks plotted their overthrow of the Crayon Monarchy, whose rulers were known for their tyrannical enforcement of mandatory bedtime storytelling rituals involving sentient spatulas.

Elsewhere, aboard the HMS Sassquatch—a dirigible powered by the dreams of mildly concerned koalas—Captain Snickerdoodle and her crew of caffeinated kazoos sailed into the Infinite Soupstorm, navigating by the laughter of gassy thunderclouds and the occasional hiccup from a sentient planet named Kevin. The ship's cargo? A precious haul of quantum pickles being delivered to the Bureau of Recursive Nonsense for analysis by their team of dancing lobsters trained in abstract algebra and soap opera critique.

Telling Your Project Story

- The poster tells the story of your project, with each section guiding your viewer through that story
- Within each section use **headers, bullet points** to structure your visual narrative
- Our template is a guide – white background, leave plenty of space!
- Use **text** sparingly… make sure it is large enough to see.
  - 30-50% of poster space, 8-12 words per line (Harvard Clinical and Translational Science Center)
  - *At least* 24pt for normal text; 48pt for headings; 72pt for titles – our template is bigger!
  - Use sans serif fonts
- Use **images/figures** to spur conversation… make them easy to see at a distance.
  - A few good images – not a million!
  - Fonts may be smaller in your graphics, but should still be easily read at a distance
  - Include captions with image source/creator
  - Use high resolution images (300 dpi or greater)!
- From a quick glance, **can you tell what this project is about? Legibility at a distance.**

Poster Elements

Elements of a Poster

1. Title and Authorship
2. Introduction/Purpose
3. Methods/Experimental Design
4. Results/ Findings
5. Conclusions
6. Next Steps
7. Acknowledgments, References, Contact Info/Learn More

This is our poster template.

You can modify everything EXCEPT the header, which needs to remain black with title and logos.

This is a suggested format, high-readability and good internal logic that corresponds with project dimensions.

HARVARD COLLEGE
Office of Undergraduate Research and Fellowships

Catchy, Brief, Large Poster Title

Your Name, Other Authors/Mentors, Institutions

PRISE
PROGRAM FOR RESEARCH IN SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING

Introduction

Introduce core challenge, question, or project aim.

Explain interest and importance. Why do we care?



Results

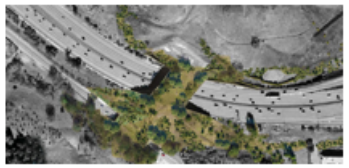
Share what you discovered or created so far

Usually this is where you would share a larger graphic

Make sure to label all graphs

Conclusion

Describe importance of your findings, in field and broadly.



Methods

Your approach to the question or problem.

How is this novel? Interesting?



Next Steps

What's next for the project?

What might be next for you?

Acknowledgements
This work was supported by a ____ award from the Harvard College Office of Undergraduate Research and Fellowships.

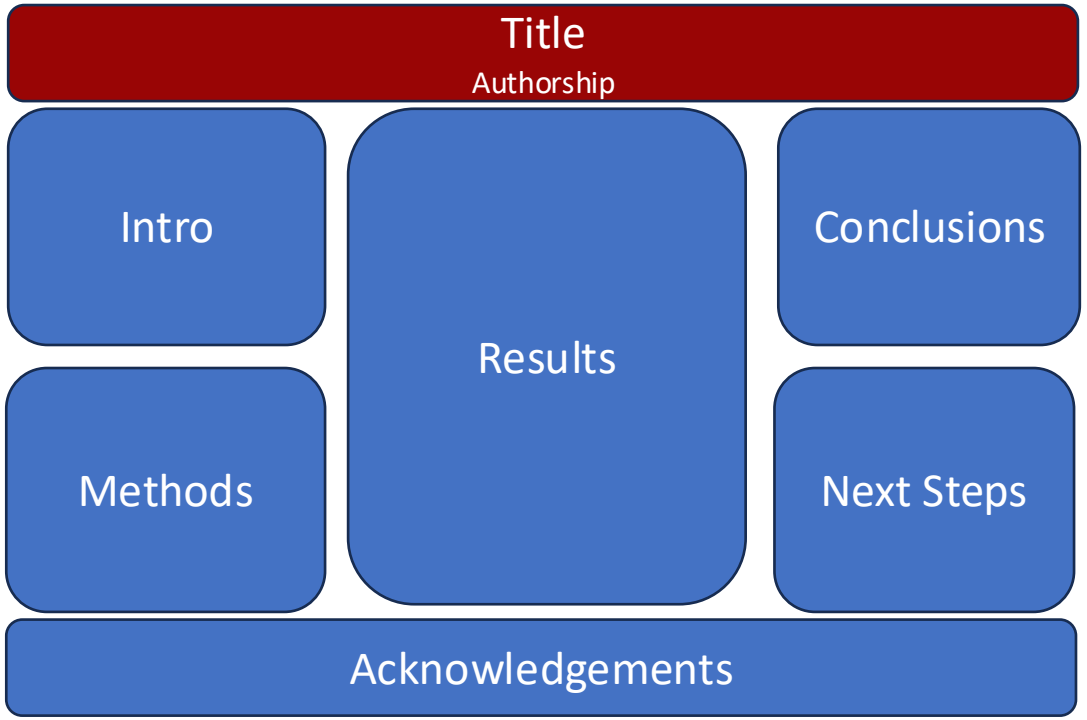
References

Contact Information/Learn More
Sometimes people put a QR code or BitLy here

YELLOW BOX IS PRINT BLEED
Don't exceed.
Delete when done.

1. Title and Authorship

- Discuss authorship with your faculty advisor/ mentor.
- Are you working on an independent project that is being advised by a faculty mentor? Or part of a larger lab/research group?
- Even if your research is narrowly specialized, include a title that doesn't require specialist expertise.



Crafting Engaging *and* Sophisticated Poster Titles

Original	Edited
Identification of the FBXO38 Substrate Binding Domain to Monomeric Zinc Finger 1 of BCL11A	Defining the FBXO38 Binding Interface with BCL11A
Emergence of Cortical Auditory Evoked Potentials Following AAV-Mediated Gene Replacement Therapy in Otoferlin-Deficient Mice	Recovery of Auditory Processing Following Gene Therapy in Otoferlin-Deficient Mice
CXR-Osteo: Using Deep Learning on Chest Radiographs to Predict Osteoporosis Risk	Predicting Osteoporosis Risk from Chest Radiographs Using Deep Learning
Quantifying Tau Mutation Penetrance Using a Large Population Control Cohort	Estimating the Penetrance of Disease-Causing MAPT Mutations
TSPO rs6971 Polymorphism and PROMIS-29 Health Domains in Chronic Pain Patients	Associations Between TSPO Genotype and Symptom Severity in Chronic Low Back Pain

Which title is easier to process at a glance? Makes you want to engage in a conversation?

Keys: What Changed?

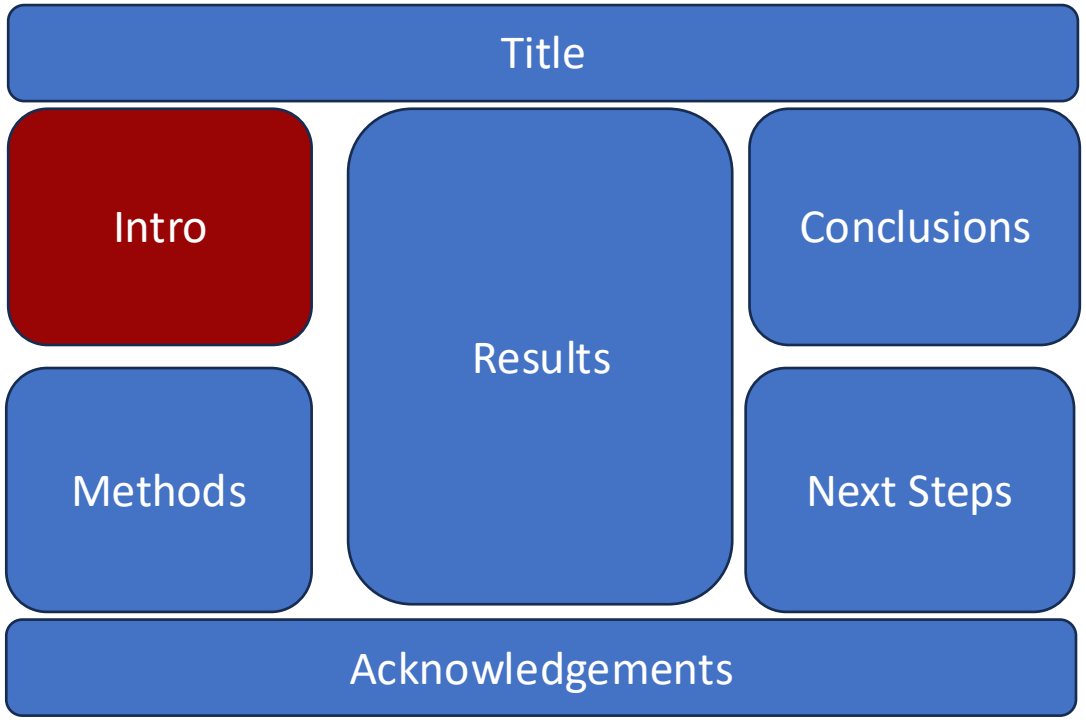
- Reduced unnecessary noun stacking.
- Used active, direct phrasing where possible.
- Removed unnecessary acronyms or project names.
- Kept domain meaningful terms (e.g., **MAPT**, **penetrance**, **gene therapy**, **TSPO**).
- Led with the question or contribution rather than the methodology.

2. Introduction/Purpose

In this section describe **what you studied and why**.

Why should the person looking at your poster care?

- Briefly describe the intellectual problem your research is examining. What is the state of research in the field most relevant to your project?
- Who else has studied this topic and what did they find?
- What industries, NGOs or public sector groups have experience with your topic?
- Are you confirming existing research? Challenging existing research? Or picking up on a neglected issue in your field?



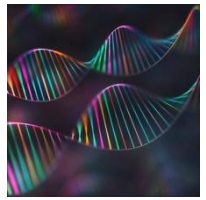
Wall of Text Makeover: Introductions

Every year, millions of people are affected by chronic pain, yet patients with similar injuries often report dramatically different experiences. Previous research suggests that neuroinflammation may contribute to these differences, but the biological mechanisms remain poorly understood. One protein involved in immune signaling, TSPO, has a common genetic variant that alters its biological function. We investigated whether this genetic difference is associated with differences in pain-related symptoms among patients with chronic low back pain.

Why do people experience chronic pain differently?



Chronic pain affects **millions of people**, but the experiences of those with similar injuries **varies widely.**



Genes that regulate **inflammation** may influence differences in pain, but mechanisms are poorly understood.



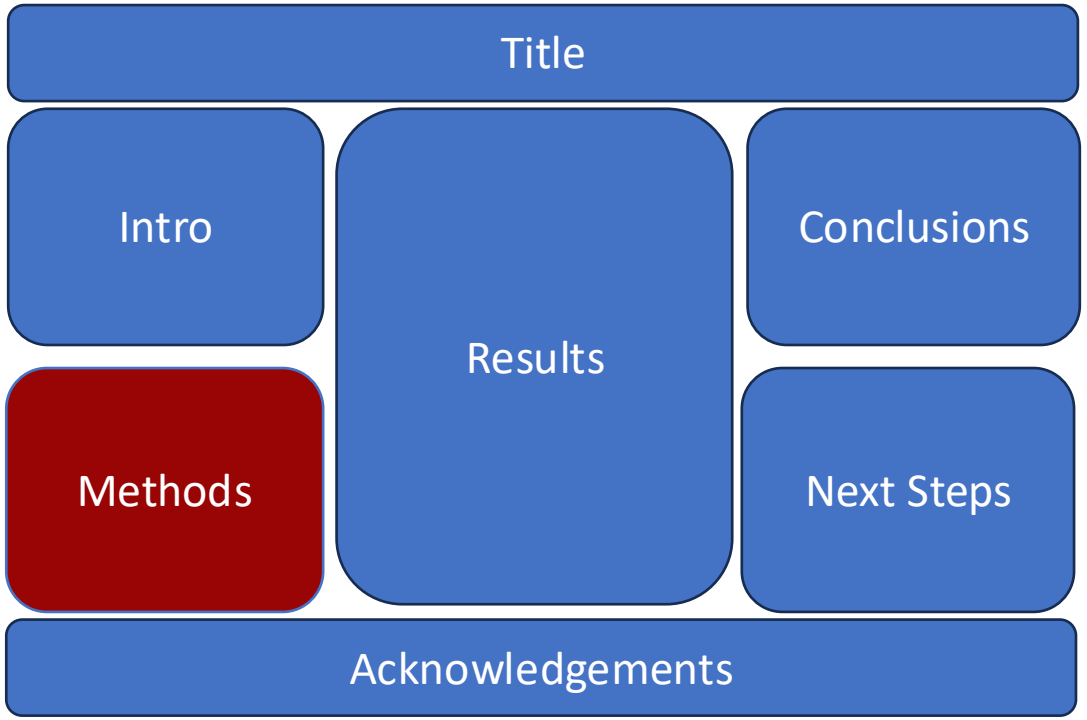
We tested whether one **genetic variant** in the protein TSPO is associated with differences in **patient symptoms.**

Which version helps a visitor understand the research question more quickly?

3. Methods/Research Design

In this section describe **what you did** to understand your question.

- What methods did you use in your project? (quantitative, qualitative, surveys, interviews, experimental, archival, etc.)
- Why did you use the methods or take the approach you did?
- What issues emerged in the process of doing research?



Clarifying What You Did

- Which methods section helps you understand *what the researchers actually did*?

Version A

Four post-stroke participants completed an experimental protocol while upper extremity kinematics **were recorded** using a 12-camera optical motion capture system**.**

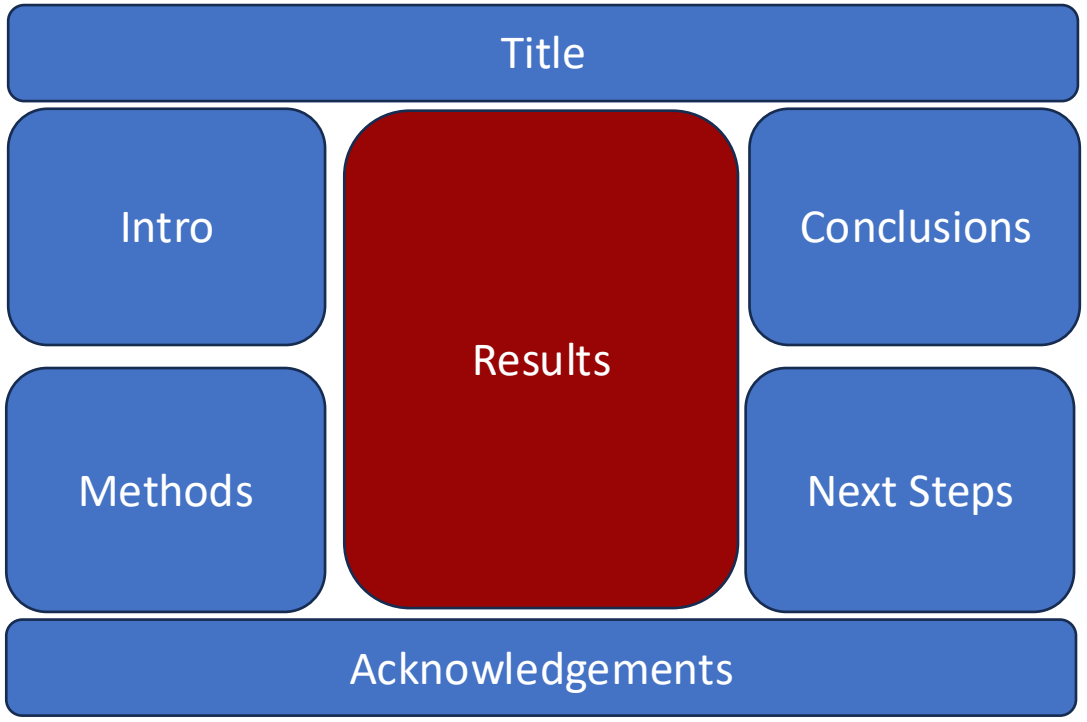
Version B

We asked stroke survivors to perform **everyday activities**—such as **brushing their teeth, combing their hair, and washing their face**—while a motion capture system **measured** how **they moved** their arms and trunks.

4. Results

In this section describe **what you learned, discovered, or created** *(so far)*.

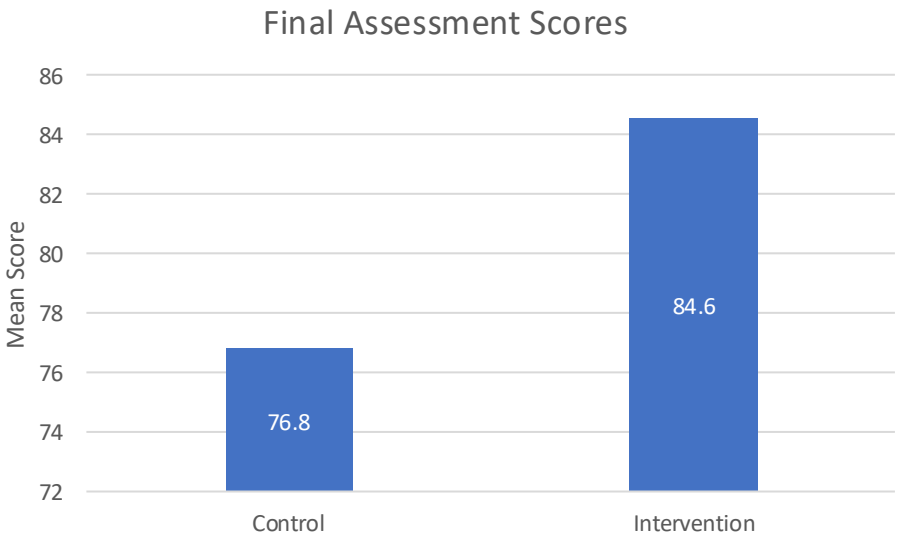
- Biggest section.
- Usually 1 or 2 graphs, charts, images!
- What are the unique findings?
- Different than or similar to what was expected?
- Results are not just data. Results are the meaning of the data.



Communicating Results

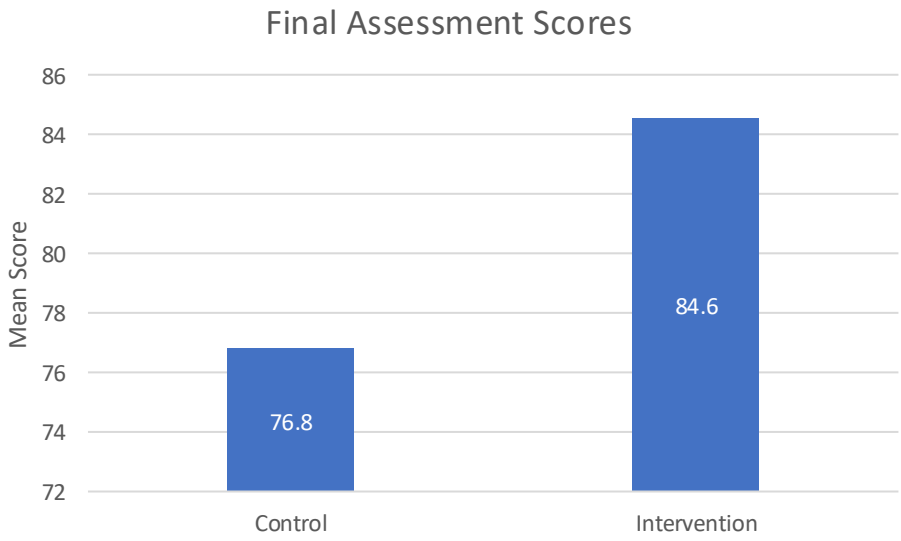
Version A

Participants in the intervention group scored significantly higher on the final assessment than the control group (84.6 ± 6.2 vs. 76.8 ± 8.4, $p < 0.001$).



Version B

The intervention improved final assessment scores. Participants scored significantly higher than the control group (84.6 ± 6.2 vs. 76.8 ± 8.4, $p < .001$).



What changed? Which version tells you what the authors concluded from the data?

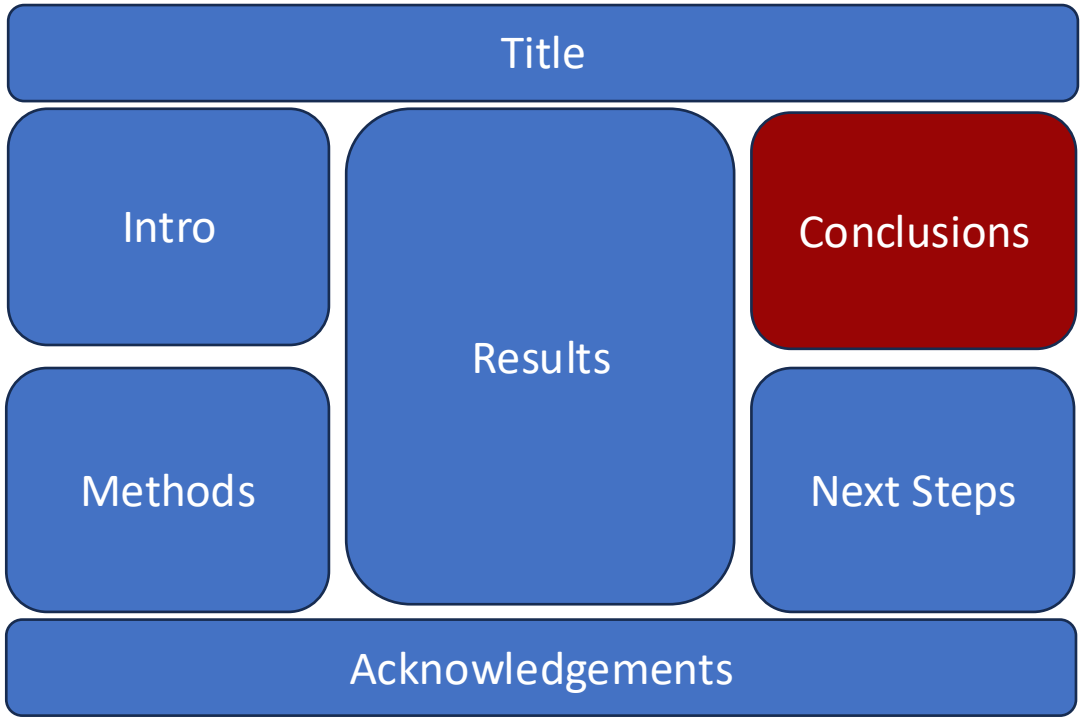
Data are the observations. Results are your interpretation of those observations.

5. Conclusions

In this section explain **what your findings mean** and **why they matter.**

- What is the most important takeaway from your project?
- How do your findings contribute to your field or address your research question?
- What are the broader implications for research, policy, practice, or creative work?
- What are the limitations of your findings or important next questions?

A conclusion should do more than repeat your results—it should help your audience understand why those results are important.



So What? Effective Conclusions

Version A	Version B	Version C
Students who completed the intervention scored significantly higher than the control group.	Students who completed the intervention scored significantly higher than the control group, suggesting this approach may improve student learning outcomes.	These findings demonstrate that this intervention should be widely adopted across higher education to improve student success.

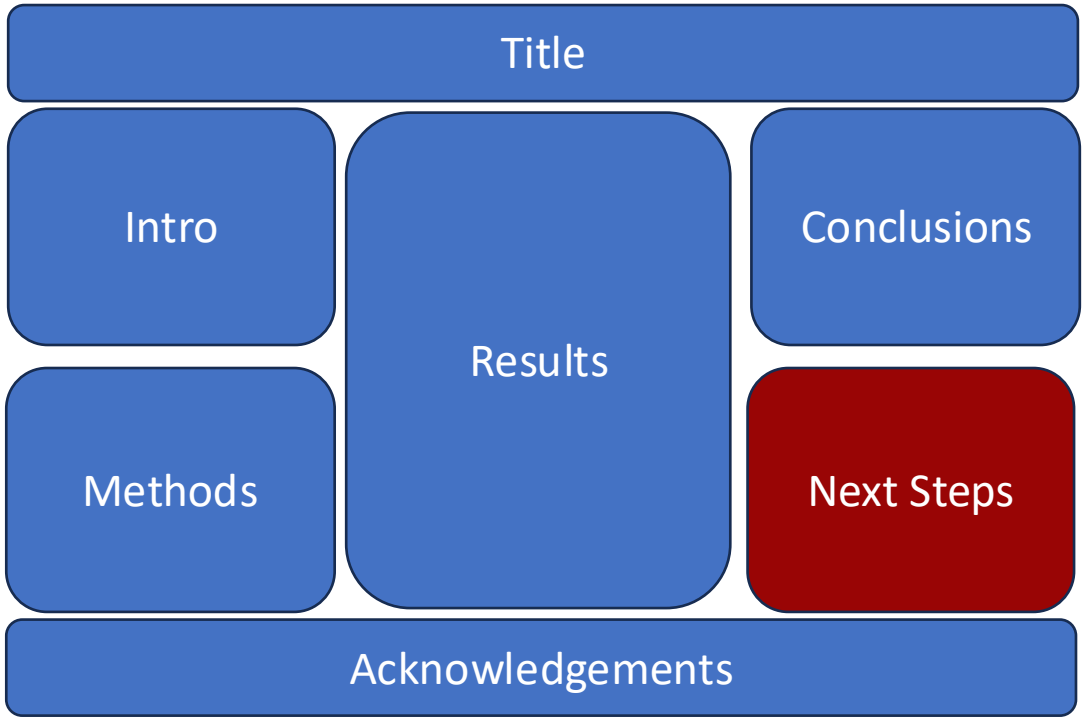
- Which version belongs in the **Results** section?
- Which version makes the strongest **Conclusion**?
- Which version goes beyond what the data can support?
- What changed between each version?

- **A** summarizes the finding.
- **B** interprets the finding and explains why it matters.
- **C** overgeneralizes and makes a recommendation that the evidence alone may not justify.

6. Next Steps

In this section explain **what is next for you and the project**.

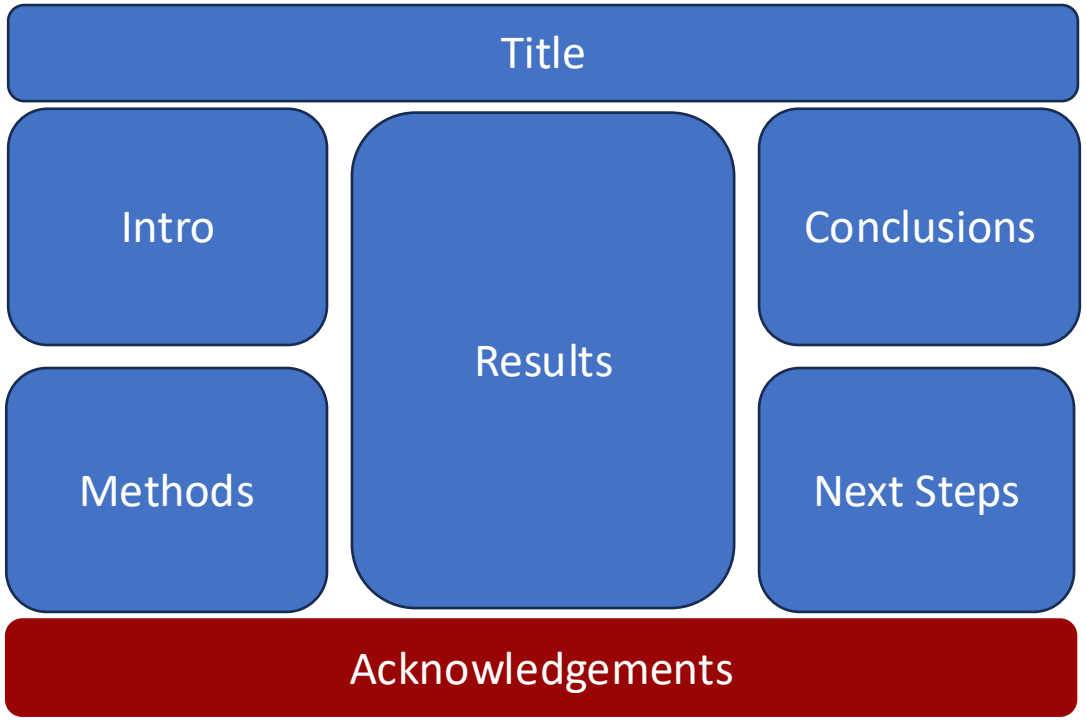
- Do you have more work to do on this project?
- Did you learn something that led you to be interested in a different topic for future research?
- Do you have further plans to share your findings?



7. Acknowledgments, References, Contact

In this section describe **the people and ideas that shaped your project.**

- List any references you cite on the poster or studies that influenced your project
- Consider including website or QR code as applicable
- Share your email address
- Name anyone who has been particularly helpful (beyond your faculty mentor/ advisor)



References

Only cite works that directly informed your project or that you discuss on the poster.

- Usually include **3–10 key references** (discipline dependent).
- Use the citation style appropriate to your field.
- References may be abbreviated for space, **provided they are complete enough for someone to identify the source.**
- A QR code linking to a full bibliography, preprint, or project website can be helpful for longer reference lists.

The Goal: If someone asks, "Where did that information come from?" they should be able to find the answer from your citations.

Citations and Figures

Citing Sources Within the Poster

If you refer to previous work, cite it briefly in the text just as you would in a manuscript. Corresponding references appear in a References section.

- **Author-year styles:** Previous studies suggest neuroinflammation contributes to chronic pain (Smith et al., 2022).
- **Numbered styles:** Previous studies suggest neuroinflammation contributes to chronic pain.[1]

Figures and Images

If a figure, photograph, map, or illustration is **not your own**, include source in caption.

- **Figure 1.** Oil spill extent following the Deepwater Horizon incident. Adapted from NOAA (2011).
- **Figure 2.** Adapted from Smith et al. (2022).

If you created the figure yourself from your own data, no citation necessary.

Finishing Your Poster

Presenting Research in Progress...

Adapt the size of different categories

- Include more content about the **background**, **methods**, and then elaborate ***potential conclusions/implications, and what's next***

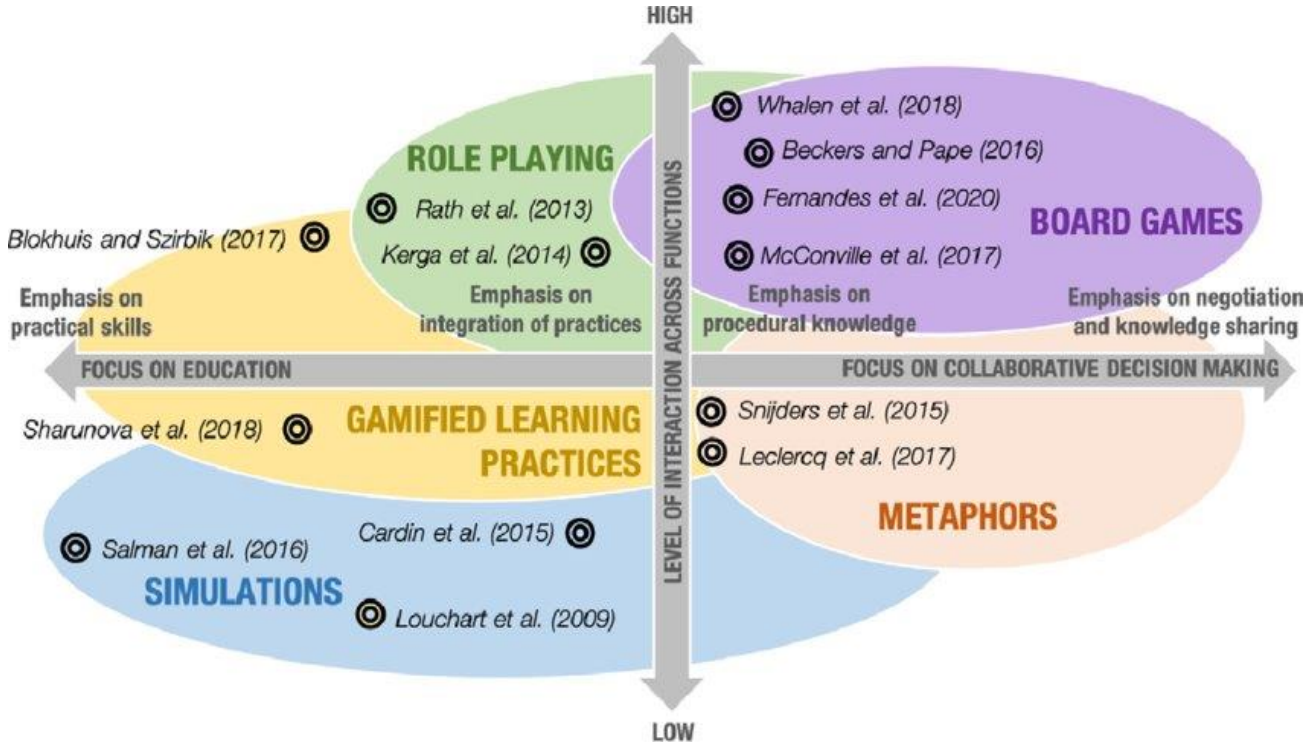
If you don't have results, that is okay.

- State this clearly.
- Share what you know so far.
- Describe what you might expect to discover.
- Describe what you have learned from the research, creative, or scientific process.

Adding Texture and Depth to Other Sections

A Sample Introduction with Elaborated Diagram of Shape of the Field

Salman et al. (2016), Cadin et al. (2015) and Louchart et al. (2009) all describe the role of simulations. Importantly simulations have a low level of interaction across functions, but a high focus on education. Simulations could also be considered closely related to some gamified learning practices, some of which also have a focus on education and low level of interaction across functions...



Scurati GW, Nylander JW, Ferrise F, Bertoni M. 2022. Sustainability awareness in engineering design through serious gaming. *Design Science* 8(12). doi:10.1017

Submitting Your Poster

Final Review Checklist

Criterion	What You're Looking For
First impression	Would someone stop and read it from 10 feet away?
Title	Accessible, engaging, appropriate for your audience
Visual hierarchy	Does your eye know where to go first?
Storytelling	Is the research question and takeaway immediately clear?
Figures	Readable, informative, conversation starters
Text	Appropriate amount, organization, and size
Layout	Effective use of whitespace and flow
Audience	Overall approach appropriate for your audience

Submitting Your Poster

Use template to craft your poster. You can change any elements except the top portion.

→

Get feedback and approval from **your advisor/mentor**

→

Make sure sizing is right

(48” wide x 36” tall; remove yellow box on template BUT keep page bleed)

↓

Double check image resolution/quality

→

Proofread! And have a friend proofread too!

→

Upload to Canvas as a PDF file and a PPTX file, title according to convention there!

Deadlines

- **Submit via Canvas by our deadline.**
- If you can get it approved by mentor and submit before then, please do as this will give us greater flexibility.
- Please don’t be late!
  - We have a tight turnaround for printing and cannot accept late posters.
    - Remember, you must submit a poster.

Presenting Your Poster

HSURV Poster Session Expectations

- HSURV Fellows are expected to be present throughout the entire afternoon.
  - **You cannot arrive late and you cannot leave early.**
- Fellows will:
  - Assist with organizing the event set-up and break-down,
  - Present their work (stay at your poster during your wave)
  - Serve as joyful and curious audience members for their peers when not presenting
- Each student presenter will be assigned a ***Presenter Wave, an Audience Wave*** and ***Poster Location***. These cannot be changed.
- URAF will forward an invitation to the project mentor that we have on file. It is your responsibility to ALSO invite them and other mentors, friends, and people you want to impress. Drum up a crowd!



Preparation: The Basics



Invite mentors, advisors, friends, people you want to impress. Even if someone cannot attend, it is a good way to build your circle of mentorship.



Update your CV, website (if you have one), and LinkedIn. You are going to meet people, so be prepared to put your best foot forward in person and online.



Dress to impress. Find a nice outfit (minimum business casual) and get comfortable wearing it.



Practice your pitch. Get ready to describe your work for different audiences, in exciting ways using your poster as prop.

Preparation: The Day of the Event



Sleep well the evenings before so you are energized for the event.



Pay careful attention to the guidance set forth in email, Canvas. The success of large events depends on EACH person doing their part.



Arrive early to set-up your poster and assist peers and organizers.

“Pitching” Your Poster: Starting the Conversation

- Short introduction to your work, get them excited.
- Someone approaches you. Usually big and baggy question:
  - “Tell me about your project?”
  - “So…what’s this about?”
- Other times, you will have to approach them. Break the ice:
  - “Hi! Can I tell you a bit about my project?”
- Either way, the goal is introduce the project elements and yourself in brief so that…they can ask you follow-up questions.
- **In the first 30–60 seconds:**
  - Introduce yourself.
  - Introduce your project.
  - Give people enough context to ask questions.



The Conversation Begins

- Good presenting is a conversation, not a speech (or an interrogation).
- As people ask questions, pay attention to:
  - What do they already know?
  - What are they curious about?
  - How much detail do they want?
- Adjust accordingly.
  - Adapt your explanation to your audience.
  - Use your poster as a guide. Point to it. Use it. Let it help tell the story.

Elements of Your Pitch: Abstract → Poster → Pitch

Abstract/Poster Element	Component of pitch	Example	Why
Background	A window into your project/problem focused on something most people in the room know and likely care about (health, $$, safety, security usually)	*Oil spills devastate ocean life and local economies – and effective, fast clean-up is nearly impossible. Naturally occurring communities of bacteria helped clean up the Deepwater Horizon spill much faster than expected.*	Introduces and connects the audience to the field and topic – and why it matters
Motivation	Why we need to know/do more about that thing	*While the bacteria worked well, little was known about the genetic underpinnings of the process.*	Introduces audience to the problem or challenge
Methods	What you did in this project	*In this project, we sequenced the DNA of oil-munching microbes to reveal the genetic potential in different bacterial species*	Helps audience understand the experimental design
Results	What your results mean	*We found a number of bacteria surprisingly capable of dealing with the more dangerous compounds.*	Explains your interpretation of the data to the audience
Conclusions/Impact	How your results contribute to the thing everyone cares about	*…improving the way we respond to oil spills.*	Connects the audience to the broader import and impact

Content adapted from Broad Research Communications Lab (https://mitcommlab.mit.edu/broad/commkit/poster/)

Post-Pitch: Responding to Questions

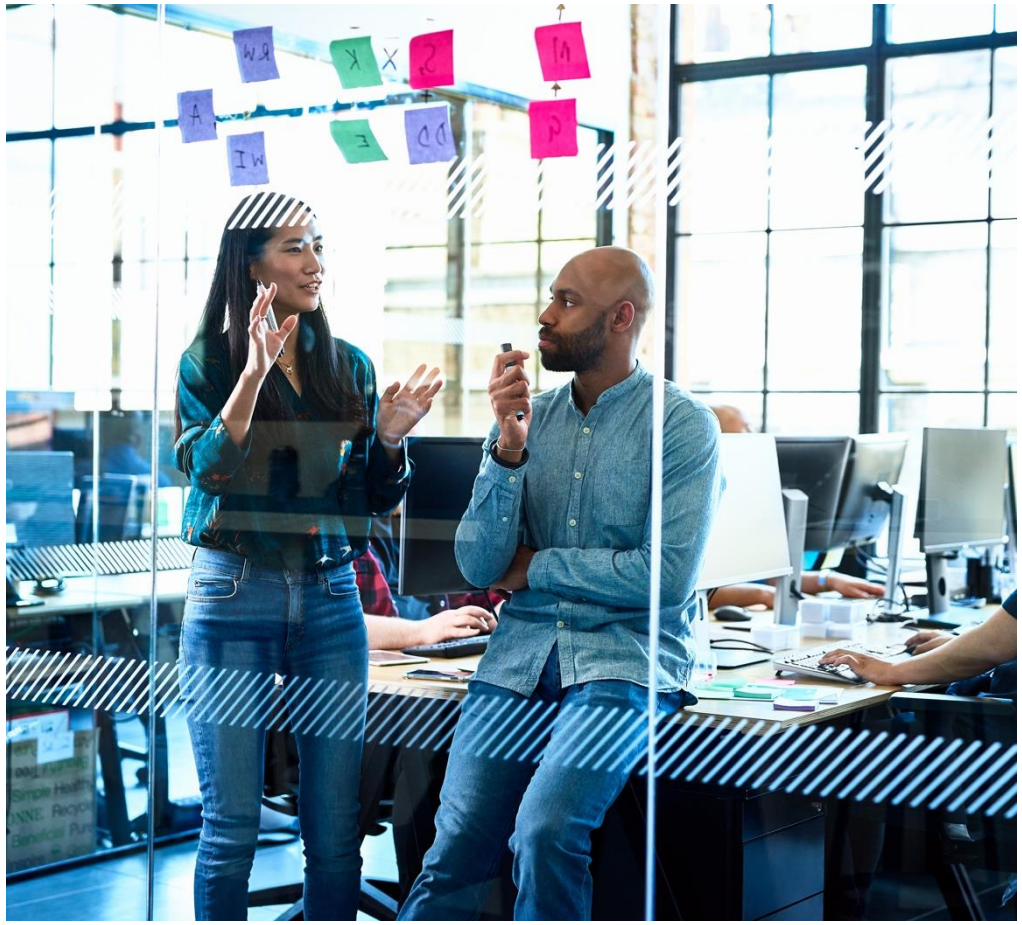
Presenting is an act of metaphor, likeness.

- Give people space to ask their questions.
- Remember, everyone knows something. It's your job to help people connect what they already know to something they don't.
- Practice approaching your project from different angles, with key takeaways for different types of audiences.

Who are you talking to?

- Friends and family
- Experts in unrelated fields
- Experts working in near fields
- Those in your field
  - Peers
  - Graduate students and postdocs
  - Advisors

Again, point to the poster! →



Mystery is not a sign of wisdom. The wiser a human being is, the simpler the language with which he expresses his thoughts.

Activate Yourself as an Audience Member

The poster session is an opportunity to learn, connect, and build your scholarly community. We'll share a guide of poster titles, topics, waves, and locations:

- **Figure out a few posters** to visit before the session begins.
  - Visit work **in your field** to learn where your discipline is headed.
  - Visit projects **outside your field** to discover new questions, methods, and perspectives.
- Look for potential **future mentors, collaborators, departments, or labs.**
- Learn to ask thoughtful questions—and listen carefully to the answers.
- Bring a small notebook to jot down ideas, people to follow up with, or techniques you might use in your own work.

HSURV Poster Session Details

- **WHAT:** Final Harvard Summer Undergraduate Research Village Poster Presentations, Two Waves!
- **WHO:** You and your mentors – and your invited guests. Over 160 students presenting with mentors and advisors in attendance.
- **WHEN:** Thursday, August 6, 2026
  - **All Student Arrival for Set-Up:** 12:00 PM (arrive at noon, no need to arrive before)
  - **Brief Opening Remarks:** 1:00 PM
  - **First Wave of Presentations:** 1:15 PM – 2:30 PM
  - **Second Wave of Presentations:** 2:45 PM – 4:00 PM
  - **Brief Closing Remarks:** 4:00 PM – 4:15 PM
  - **All Student Clean-Up and Event Breakdown:** 4:15 PM – 5:00 PM
- **WHERE:** Harvard Graduate School of Education Gutman Conference Center

Afterwards, join peers for **HSURV DINNER CELEBRATION**

The Rubenstein Treehouse at 6:00 PM.

Invited Speaker: Professor Evelynn Hammonds, one of the originators of the Research Village

Questions?

Contact us at UndergradResearch@fas.harvard.edu